Revisión: 1 de octubre de 2026

FAQs about the UPM PhD Program in Artificial Intelligence

October 1st, 2026

The information contained in this document is indicative. What is valid is the applicable regulations in each case. In any case, you can find more information on the official website of the programme and in the UPM doctoral FAQ. If your question is not here, write to us at doctorado.dia@fi.upm.es.

1. ACCESS, ADMISSION AND ENROLMENT

1.1 Can the UPM Doctoral Programme in Artificial Intelligence be carried out online or remotely?

The PhD program in Artificial Intelligence at the Polytechnic University of Madrid is a program conceived and officially approved as FACE-to-FACE.

However, the interested candidate could be a student of the program if he or she takes into account some requirements that must be met:

- All students must carry out a series of training activities (Actividades Formativas, AFs), all of which are taught in person. After consultation and justification by the student, a teacher may authorize them to be taken online.
- Students whose admission is conditional on taking complementary training (Complementos Formativos, CFs) from among the subjects and seminars of the *Master's Degree in Artificial Intelligence by the UPM (MUIA),* will have to attend in person the subjects that cover the credits that have been assigned to them, since the MUIA is a face-to-face degree. Again, after consultation and justification by the applicant, a professor may authorize them to be taken online.
- In addition, you would have to look for a thesis supervisor who agrees to direct the research remotely and at a common availability schedule. It is recommended to contact in advance with the professors who may be interested in directing the research work (you can see the lines of research of the program and the professors who develop each of them at this link). This way you can better assess the viability of the proposal.

1.2 How long does it take to do the PhD?

It depends on whether you do your doctoral studies full-time or part-time. In general terms, the ordinary period for the development of the thesis will be a maximum of four years full-time or seven years part-time. A one-year extension can be requested. If you want more details you can find the regulations that govern it at this link.

1.3 Is *access* the same as *admission*?

No. They are two different processes.

- **Access** involves a review of whether the applicant meets the requirements established in the Spanish law to pursue doctoral studies in Spain. The process is carried out by the International Doctoral School (Escuela Internacional de Doctorado, EID). The documentation that is analysed is the one that the applicant provides through the "Procedures" platform. For more information, go to the following link to the UPM website.

- **Admission**. Once access has been granted, the file goes to the doctoral programme that the applicant has indicated as the first option for evaluation. The Academic Committee of this doctoral programme will evaluate the documentation taking as a criterion the requirements indicated in the verification report of the degree. For the PhD programme in Artificial Intelligence at the UPM, the scale to be followed can be seen at this link to the programme's website.

1.4 How and on what dates is pre-registration done?

The procedure and deadlines are indicated at this link, where you will also find access to the "Procedures" platform that manages these initial processes. If you have any questions about the process, please contact the International Doctoral School through the platform itself.

1.5 What are the entry requirements?

Those established by current legislation. Having access is only a precondition to be admitted.

1.6 What is the admission process like?

The selection criteria that the academic committee of the program will use for admissions, together with their corresponding assessment, can be seen at this link.

1.7 What is the recommended entry profile?

You will find it described in this link.

1.8 Do I need to accredit my training in English?

No, no official English certificate is required for admission as a documentary requirement, although a B2 level is recommended in the entry profile (which does not have to be accredited). Some compulsory training activities are taught in Spanish and others in English.

1.9 Do I have to contact a teacher before doing the pre-registration procedures?

Formally, it is not mandatory to submit the application on the *Procedures* platform. However, having a letter of recommendation signed by a member of the Academic Committee of the Program has a decisive weight when it comes to obtaining admission.

1.10 How to contact the professors of the program to discuss the feasibility of directing a thesis?

In this link you can find the research lines of the program and the professors/researchers who develop them. Next to the names, you can see their contact email address. Contact them directly.

1.11 If I apply for access and admission outside the ordinary period, what will be my start date from which the deadlines begin to count?

In the doctorate, only two start dates are used: October 1st and March 1st. The one that is closest to your admission date will be assigned (in general, before Christmas it will be assigned as a start date on October 1st, and after Christmas it will be assigned as a start date on March 1st.

However, it must be taken into account that if you have to take complementary training, these will begin on the dates determined by MUIA.

1.12 What is the difference between a thesis supervisor (director) and a thesis tutor?

The tutor looks after the doctoral candidate's relationship with the CAPD. They must be UPM teaching and research staff with a permanent appointment, and their role is mainly administrative. The supervisor (director), by contrast, is a researcher in the programme and takes on the academic and scientific responsibility for the work.

1.13 How much does the PhD cost?

The public prices for university studies (fees) for postgraduate studies at the University are set each year by the Community of Madrid by Decree. The latest information we have is that published in the FAQ on the UPM website. Once you have received the admission letter, it will contain an estimate of the TOTAL cost (not annual) of the studies.

1.14 Are there grants to finance doctoral studies?

In this link you can find the information offered by the University.

The grants are processed directly by the applicant; that is, the secretariat of the programme does not offer support or intermediation to obtain funding for the studies.

1.15 Can I do an industrial doctorate, in collaboration with my company?

Yes, but you need to: a) look for a professor in the programme willing to supervise it: you can search in the lines and research teams, and b) apply for authorisation to carry out an industrial doctorate. Information on the process you must follow and the regulations that govern it can be found at this link.

1.16 Can I do a PhD under international co-supervision?

Yes. You must follow the procedure indicated in the regulations, which you can find at this link.

1.17 Can I do a PhD with an international mention?

Yes. Information about this can be found at this link.

1.18 My degree is from outside Spain, do I have to have it recognised to access it?

Access to doctoral studies is an evaluation carried out by the International Doctoral School. If you have any questions, contact them through the *Procedures* platform.

1.19 Who manages the enrolment? I have a problem with the platform or payment

The doctoral programme **does not manage enrolment**: it is managed by the Student Secretariat of the ETSI Computer Engineers. For any problems with deadlines, payments, appointments or access to the enrolment platform, write directly to secretaria@fi.upm.es.

1.20 Do I have to register for the thesis defence?

The defence of the thesis must be registered when you are about to defend the thesis.

If the system includes it by default without it being necessary to do so, it is an error. Go to the Student Secretary to correct it. The defense fee can be paid at the time of requesting the deposit.

1.21 Can I enrol part-time, or change from full-time to part-time?

Yes. To apply for part-time admission, you must upload a justification of your application to the procedures platform. And in the event that you apply for full-time admission and in the course of your studies you need to move to part-time, you must apply through the THESIS platform (which you will have access to once you are a student of the programme). Changes in dedication have their own time window (usually around June) and apply to the following academic year, not the current one. You can find the regulations at this link.

1.22 The tuition fee does not match what I expected

The amount that appears on your admission letter is the **estimated total of all the years** of the doctorate, not the cost of a single course. Please also bear in mind that the general amount may change if your admission is subject to taking credits of complementary training. If you have any questions or discrepancies, consult the Student Secretary's Office.

2. DEVELOPMENT OF THE THESIS

2.1 How do I change tutor or thesis supervisor?

The change of director is requested through the THESIS platform.

If you want to request a change of tutor, send a reasoned letter to the academic committee of the programme setting out the reasons for the request and the proposal for a new tutor. The letter must be signed by you and the new tutor. You must send it to the programme's email address: doctorado.dia@fi.upm.es

2.2 How do I add an external expert as a co-director?

The external expert must meet the requirements of the program and the UPM in order to supervise the thesis. You can find more details at this link.

The process is as follows:

- The registration of a researcher will be carried out online by the interested party through the THESIS platform. This platform requires an @upm.es access account. If the interested party does not have a @upm account, they must request it from the programme coordinator (doctorado.dia@fi.upm.es) indicating their name, surname, DNI/NIE/passport and a contact email address. To request registration, they must attach all the documentation requested by the platform.
- Once the academic committee (CAPD) receives the application through the platform, it will evaluate it at the next meeting it has scheduled, and in the event that the resolution is favorable, it will submit the application to the Doctoral Area Committee (CAD), which is competent to resolve these applications. The final resolution will reach the external expert.
- Once the external expert has been registered in the programme, the student must request the co-supervision of their thesis through the THESIS platform. As in the previous case, the CAPD will review the application and, if approved, will submit it to the CAD, which will be the final decision.

You can find in this link the regulations that govern the registration of a researcher in the doctoral programs of our university.

2.3 What documentation must I submit each year?

Each academic year you must submit two documents:

- The Activities Document (an Excel file in which you must fill in several fields that are requested. This document, converted into a pdf, must reach the CAPD through the email doctorado.dia@fi.upm.es within the period indicated, signed by the student, their tutor, their director and, if any, their co-director.
- The annual research plan, which is processed through the THESIS platform. **Failure to submit the Research Plan on time may lead to expulsion from the programme**.

2.4 Can I request an extension if I have not managed to finish my thesis within the ordinary deadline?

Yes. If the doctoral student has not deposited the thesis before the end of the ordinary period, he or she may request an extension. If granted, the extension will last for one year.

The request for extension must be submitted at least 120 calendar days before the date on which the ordinary period ends.

All procedures are carried out through the THESIS platform. The regulations governing it can be consulted at this link.

2.5 Who do I write to when I have questions?

The procedures related to the doctorate are managed by various university bodies.

- For everything related to enrolment (formalisation of enrolment, payments, refunds, proof of enrolment, deadlines, etc.) you can contact the student secretary's office.
- For queries about access, operation of the THESIS platform or changes of email account in THESIS, contact the International Doctoral School through the contact they have on the same THESIS platform. You can also write to the email account doctorado@upm.es.
- For all other queries related to the PhD in Artificial Intelligence program itself, please contact the program through the doctorado.dia@fi.upm.es email account.

2.6 How to apply for a certificate of the program for a procedure (visa, scholarship, stay...)?

Any certificate that has to do with your enrollment (being enrolled), you must request it from the student secretary.

The secretary of the program can issue statements that confirm a specific aspect of your situation in the program, but it cannot certify things "in the future", that is, future dates or enrollments not yet made. Nor can it certify economic data. The different official grants request their own documents, but in general these signatures require a prior agreement of the Academic Committee; therefore, if you need a signature for that, remember to do it in time for it to be discussed on the agenda of the next meeting of the committee.

2.7 What do I need to have published in order to deposit the thesis?

In general terms, in order for a doctoral thesis to be admitted for defense, it must have at least one article admitted for definitive publication in a journal indexed in the Journal Citation Reports (JCR) up to the third quartile (Q3) of the last year published or the year in which the merit was produced. In the article, the student must appear with affiliation "Polytechnic University of Madrid" (without prejudice to the fact that another institution may also appear). You can consult more details at this link.

2.8 How can I pre-evaluate my doctoral thesis?

There are three possible ways to do the pre-assessment:

- By quality indications. To do this, it is necessary to have at least 2 items that meet the requirements indicated in the FAQ above.
- By expert reports.
- By pre-reading.

3. TRAINING ACTIVITIES

3.1 What are training activities?

These are transversal academic activities, not articulated in ECTs, which the doctoral student must carry out **in** parallel to the preparation of their doctoral thesis in order to acquire specialised and advanced research skills.

There are 10 training activities. AF1-AF8 are face-to-face, with a timetable and classroom. AF9 and AF10 are mobility training activities.

It should be noted that to obtain a pass in the AF2 PhD Symposium, the student must attend **two editions**.

Its implementation must be recorded in the Activities Document and in the Annual Research Plan.

3.2 What are the training activities?

In this link you can see what they are, their duration, description, time planning, control procedures, learning outcomes, competencies, etc.

They are normally planned and approved in the first term of the course. Once approved and their calendar established, students are informed.

3.3 Do I have to take them all?

Obtaining a favourable report on the training activities of the programme is a requirement to be able to defend the doctoral thesis. To obtain it, it is necessary to have participated and obtained the qualification of "pass" in at least 80% of them (i.e. in eight of them), as long as the training activities taken allow the **achievement of all the competences indicated in the verification report of the degree** that are associated with the Training Activities. In other words, at least 80% of the PAs with which 100% of the competences are covered must be taken.

3.4 Can I "validate" training activities for other activities previously carried out?

The decision corresponds to the academic committee of the programme. As a general rule, training activities are not validated, but if you consider that you have achieved the competences of a specific activity and meet the indications in each of them, you can submit an application to the academic committee explaining the activities you have carried out, and attaching the certificates that accredit it. The academic committee will evaluate and let you know the result.

3.5 How do I convalidate AF10?

The same as indicated in the previous question: first check the website corresponding to that training activity, and once you check that you comply with what is indicated in it, submit a request to the academic committee indicating the activities you have carried out (attendance at seminars, conferences, courses, workshops, tutorials, project meetings, etc.) and attaching the certificates that accredit each of them. The academic committee, at its next meeting, will review the documentation and make a decision on the matter.

3.6 Can I attend the training activities remotely (on-line)?

Contact the teachers who develop the subject and ask them directly.

3.7 How do I prove that I have attended the training activities organized by the EID, such as the PhD Symposium?

When you do the activity, ask for a certificate of attendance and participation, and send it to us by email to doctorado.dia@fi.upm.es.

4. COMPLEMENTARY TRAINING

4.1 Will I have to take complementary training?

It depends on your previous training. In this link to the program's website you will be able to see, depending on your previous degree, the training complements that will be assigned to you at admission.

4.2 How long do I have to take the complementary training?

The enrolment and admission regulations read as follows in Article 13: "*Students who must take and pass complementary training at the request of the Academic Committee of the Doctoral Programme must complete these complements within the period indicated by the aforementioned Commission. In any case, these complements must be carried out at most during the first year of academic supervision in the programme, except for reasons of major cause that must be justified before the CAPD.* "

4.3 Do the complementary training courses have to be from the Master's Degree in Artificial Intelligence from the UPM (MUIA)?

Yes, compulsory. They cannot be taken from another degree.

4.4 Can the complementary training courses be taken remotely or online?

The *Master's Degree in Artificial Intelligence* is a face-to-face master's degree. Despite this, you can contact the professor of the subject(s) you have chosen to ask about this possibility. If there is a sufficient reason, there are teachers who can allow it.

4.5 Among the complementary training courses that can be taken is the subject "Seminars" (10 ECTS) of the MUIA. How does this subject work?

To pass the subject "Seminars", which belongs to the second semester, the student can choose the seminars with total freedom, but with the obligation to reach 10 ECTS. This means that, if you do not choose both S1 and S2, you need SEVEN seminars. And they must be taken IN THE SAME academic year.

4.6 In which semester is the subject "Seminars" taught?

In the second semester. The dates and times will be established and published before Christmas.

4.7 In which language are the MUIA subjects taught?

The languages used in the teaching of the MUIA are Spanish (Spanish) and English. To find out in which language the subject you want to choose as a training complement is taught, you can look at the learning guides at this link.

4.8 When do MUIA classes start?

In the 26-27 academic year, classes begin the week of September 7, except for the S1 seminar, the first edition of which will be held on September 2, 3 and 4.

4.9 Where can I find the annual teaching plan for the current academic year?

You can download it at this link

5. Useful Links and Contacts

- Procedures Portal (Portal de Trámites): access, pre-registration and everything managed by the International Doctoral School.
- THESIS: management of your thesis (Annual Research Plan, prior evaluation, deposit, changes of tutor/director, co-supervision).
- Research lines and teams: where to find professors by area to request thesis direction or letter of support.
- Training activities and doctoral thesis: programme pages with details of each procedure.
- UPM scholarships and grants and UPM doctoral FAQ.
- **Student Secretary's Office** — secretaria@fi.upm.es: enrolment, fees and official certificates.
- **International Doctoral School** — doctorado@upm.es: access, pre-registration and procedures of the Rectorate.
- **PhD Program in AI** — doctorado.dia@fi.upm.es: any other questions about the program.